mezzanine floor. By 9.30 p.m., the staff had received a call from a hotel operator alerting them of the terrorist threat. Thomas Varghese, a senior waiter, acted instinctively. The forty-eight-year-old Taj veteran, who had spent three decades in the hotel, got the fifty-odd guests to go down to the kitchen area where they were given tablecloths to cover themselves, as many were shivering. That was when Sunu, his wife, called him. He told her that there was an emergency and that he could not talk to her. He also advised her not to call again as it would prevent him from giving his full attention to getting the guests out safely, Sunu recalls.

They waited until the security personnel informed Varghese that it would be safe to evacuate the guests. The waiter, who was also an active trade union activist, gathered his juniors, put them in charge of five guests each and sent them down the stairs. He chose to be at the tail end to ensure that he could guide the others to lead the guests to safety. But when it was finally his turn to leave with the last batch of guests, one of his colleagues spotted terrorists running towards them and screamed at Varghese to escape. He replied that he could not do so while the guests were in danger.

The terrorists ran towards them and downed all they could find in a hail of bullets. Varghese was hit in the thigh. Assuming that they had killed everyone, the terrorists walked away. Varghese then called out to his friend Prashant to come to their aid, narrates Sunu. But though Varghese could not see them, the terrorists were within earshot. They heard him call for help, ran back and opened automatic fire, killing him instantaneously. His wife recalls his bravery while fighting tears, but with a sense of pride.

Such heroic scenes played out in several quarters of the large hotel. The staff assumed responsibilities they had not been trained for, and it made leaders of them. Waiters morphed into bodyguards and chefs into wardens. Hemant Oberoi, the head chef of the hotel, personally made sandwiches for the guests and assumed the role of a guardian as he escorted some guests to safety. He got staff volunteers to form a protective cordon while the guests tried to escape. But it proved costly. Upon spotting them, one of the terrorists opened fire and in the hail of bullets, many of the protectors fell victim; among them were several young chefs.

Even the staff who had been evacuated came back to their stations later. Most importantly, these included the Taj’s team of telephone operators, many of them women, who had refused to go home. They stayed back the whole night, manning the communication hub, whose effective functioning